

"All Roads Lead to ChatGPT": How Generative AI is Eroding Social Interactions and Student Learning Communities

Key Takeaways

- 13 of 17 interviewed computing students reported that peer help-seeking is now mediated by generative AI, with classmates redirecting questions to ChatGPT or sharing AI-generated outputs rather than providing authentic personal assistance.
- Even students who never use genAI themselves are affected indirectly, as the help they receive from peers often originates from ChatGPT, making AI mediation effectively unavoidable in computing learning communities.
- Seven participants spontaneously reported experiencing shame and stigma around genAI use, fearing labels like 'lazy' or 'stupid,' which creates a paradoxical norm of private reliance coupled with public hesitation—even when instructors explicitly permit AI use.
- Students observed that genAI homogenizes learning by replacing diverse peer perspectives and critical discourse with uniform outputs, captured in the metaphor that AI gives 'Times New Roman' while peers offer distinctive 'handwriting.'
- Mentorship connections between senior and junior students are weakening, reducing access to the 'hidden curriculum' of unwritten academic and professional norms—a loss that disproportionately harms first-generation and underrepresented students who cannot rely on family networks for this guidance.
- 11 of 17 participants reported increased feelings of isolation, with previously active communal spaces like class Discord servers falling silent because genAI now answers questions that once drove peer interaction.
- The motivational impact of genAI is bifurcated: students motivated by peer collaboration and shared struggle reported demotivation and loss of purpose, while students motivated by efficiency appreciated reduced frustration and faster progress.
- The authors argue that educators must intentionally design interventions that balance AI integration with sustaining peer interaction, mentorship, and community building, as these social dimensions are irreplaceable for learning, belonging, and retention.

Common Areas of Confusion

- Readers may conflate the paper's qualitative, exploratory findings with established causal claims; the study is based on 17 interviews using reflexive thematic analysis, and the authors themselves note the evidence is anecdotal and not yet empirically corroborated, so the findings represent perceived trends rather than proven effects.
- The concept of 'AI-mediated help-seeking' can be confusing because it encompasses multiple distinct behaviors—peers redirecting someone to ChatGPT, peers silently using ChatGPT and passing along its output as their own help, and students individually choosing AI over peers—which have different social implications but are sometimes discussed interchangeably.

- The simultaneous normalization and stigmatization of genAI use appears contradictory: genAI is described as 'unavoidable' and 'inevitable' while also being associated with shame and social risk, which may confuse readers until they recognize this reflects a genuine paradox in evolving social norms rather than an inconsistency in the data.
- Readers may misunderstand the 'hidden curriculum' concept as referring to formal course content; it actually refers to unwritten rules, professional strategies, cultural norms, and tacit knowledge transmitted through informal mentorship and social interaction, which genAI cannot replicate.
- The paper's scope is limited to undergraduate computing students at R1 universities in North America, but readers may overgeneralize the findings to all disciplines, educational levels, or cultural contexts, especially given the paper's broadly framed title and conclusions.
- The finding that genAI both increases and decreases motivation may seem contradictory, but this arises because different students derive motivation from different sources—mastery and competence versus social collaboration versus efficiency—and genAI affects each motivational orientation differently.
- Readers may assume the paper argues against all genAI use, when in fact the authors acknowledge concrete benefits such as reduced frustration, personalized explanations, and accessibility; their concern is specifically about the unintended erosion of social structures, not about the tools themselves being inherently harmful.